

Dirt: A Play in Composted Texts

Thumbnail image: A blue and grey filtered photograph of a forest path.

Sound: A cowbell wind chime rings in an irregular, arrhythmic pattern.

Video (title slide): Black slide with white text: "Dirt: A Play in Composted Texts." Fade into new white text that reads "Act One: A Garden" and "Characters: Compost, Soil, and Dirt."

Stage Director (feminine voice speaking): Act One. Lights up—gray-ish and muted.

Video: Black screen with white text: "Lights Up." Fades into a black and white close up video of seedling plants growing from dirt.

Stage Director (speaking): Stage center: Dirt sits with bare feet resting on an empty garden bed. Stage left: Soil occupies an enormous terra cotta pot. Compost walks in a slow circle around the stage.

Video: Close-up fades to footage of cut vegetation heaped in a wooden pallet compost bin.

Dirt (masculine voice speaking): Dirt is made up of sand, silt, and clay, and it may be rocky. It has none of the minerals, nutrients, or living organisms found in soil. It is not an organized ecosystem. You cannot plant a productive garden in dirt.

Soil (feminine voice speaking): Dirt and soil are not the same thing, but they are certainly related. Think of soil as having dirt in it, while also having extra things in it that make it superior to mere dirt. You can't have soil without dirt.

Video: Compost bin video fades into a color image of a compost bin full of fresh dark soil.

Compost (multiple feminine voices speaking at once): All soil began as dirt.

Video: Fade into a black slide with white text, which reads "Lights Out."

Stage Director (speaking): Lights out.

Video: Black screen with white letters: "Lights Out." Fades into white letters that read "Act Two: A Compost Bin" and "Characters: Compost, Soile, and Dirt."

Stage Director (speaking): Act Two. Lights up—blue-ish and muted.

Video: Fade into video of a person using a pitchfork to turn the compost pile.

Stage Director (speaking): Dirt and Soil remain where they left off—sitting and standing. Compost walks in a slow circle around the stage.

Compost (multiple voices speaking at once): Compost is a broad term explaining the process of recycling organic materials.

Soil (speaking): My analysis provides a unified framework with which to understand the use of dirty and clean as metaphors to categorize objects, events and actions in the moral domain.

Dirt (speaking): I suggest that the dirty-clean distinction is useful for understanding broader cultural issues and I show that the conceptualization of certain non-moral properties can be understood using the same framework.

Compost (multiple voices speaking at once): Dirt Is Dead.

Video: The person turning compost pauses, loosens a stem from the pitchfork, and removes a stick. Fade to black

Stage Director (speaking): Dirt and Soil rise, move to center stage where they high five. They move to center stage behind the garden bed. Dirt sits. Soil stands. Lights out.

Video: Black screen with white text: "Lights Out." Fade into new white letters, which read "Act Three: The World" and "Characters: Compost, Soil, and Dirt."

Stage Director (speaking): Act Three.

Video: Black screen with white text: "Lights Up." The screen fades into video from the perspective of someone walking along a forest path. On the left side of the frame, several tall logs lean against a wooden structure. On the right, a small stack of logs rests on the ground beside a PVC pipe protruding from the earth. Further in the background, buckets hang from a wooden pallet."

Stage Director (speaking): Dirt and Soil lay on their sides on either side of the garden bed, looking lovingly at each other. Compost walks in a circle around the stage. Lights up.

Soil (speaking): Dirt is an unclean matter, especially when in contact with a person's clothes, skin, or possessions. In such cases, they are said to become dirty.

Dirt (speaking): Common types of dirt include: Debris: scattered pieces of waste or remains. Dust: a general powder of organic or mineral matter. Filth: foul matter such as excrement. Grime: a black, ingrained dust such as soot. Soil: The term 'soil' may refer to unwanted substances or dirt that are deposited onto surfaces such as clothing.

Video: Camera follows the perspective of someone walking into the forest. Right of path, a tall tripod of thin bamboo stakes can now be seen. Left of the path there are trees and undergrowth. The path itself is lined by logs and leads into a dense forest.

Compost (multiple voices speaking at once): For the purposes of learning, it can be useful to draw such distinctions.

Video: Fades to black. Fade in white letters—the title of a poem: “Ode to Dirt, Sharon Olds.” Each word of the following lines brightens sequentially then dims, one by one:

“when I understood

I have never honored you as a living equal

I was ashamed of myself

as if I had not recognized a character who looked so different from me.

Sounds: The cowbell wind chime tolls irregularly. A bird sings.

Video: Fade into black slide with white letters that brighten sequentially, then dim:

“but now I can see us all

made of the same basic materials—

cousins of that first exploding from nothing”

Sounds: The cowbell wind chime tolls.

Video: Fade into black slide with large multicolored letters: “Lights Out.” Fade into a black slide with white letters:

Cast

Stage Director: Freddie Harris

Dirt: Andrew Lightman

Soil: Michelle LaFrance

Compost: Jenn Fishman, Nancy Small, and Rebecca Rickly